

EARLY CHILDHOOD CARE AND EDUCATION (ECCE)

Comprehensive Study Notes on Foundational Neuro–Development, Play–Based & Toy Pedagogy, Activity Corners, and Holistic Assessment (Units 1 to 4)

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Curriculum Session 2026

SYLLABUS BLUEPRINT & MARKS ALLOCATION

4 Core Units • 35 External Marks

Unit 1

8 Marks

Definition, Nature & Significance
Neuroscience, 5 Domains, ECCE Agencies

Unit 2

10 Marks

Pedagogical Approaches to ECCE
Play Spectrum, Toy/Inquiry, Rote Trap

Unit 3

9 Marks

Classroom Planning & Management
Activity Corners, Theme Webs, Community

Unit 4

8 Marks

Assessment in ECCE
HPC 360°, Portfolio, 8 Quality Standards

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UNIT 1: DEFINITION, NATURE AND SIGNIFICANCE OF ECCE

Foundational Brain Architecture, Panchakosha Domains & Institutional Agencies

WEIGHTAGE: 8 MARKS

1.1 & 1.2 CONCEPT, MEANING & NEUROSCIENCE OF EARLY CHILDHOOD

NEP 2020 Foundational Stage

Early Childhood Care and Education (ECCE) refers to the holistic support, care, nutrition, health, and structured play-based stimulation provided to children from **prenatal stage up to 8 years of age**. In the pedagogical framework of NEP 2020 and the National Curriculum Framework for Foundational Stage (NCF-FS 2022), ECCE constitutes the critical core of the **5 + 3 + 3 + 4 architecture**, covering age 3 to 6 in Anganwadi / Pre-Primary (Ka–Shreni / Balvatika) and age 6 to 8 in Classes 1 and 2.

85% Brain Development

Neuroscience establishes that over 85% of an individual's cumulative brain development occurs before the age of 6. Synaptic connections form at an unprecedented rate of over 1,000,000 per second.

Sensitive Periods

Windows of developmental plasticity where neural pathways for sensory perception, language syntax, emotional regulation, and social bonding are most malleable.

Heckman Curve Equation

Nobel Laureate James Heckman proved that investing in high-quality early childhood yields the highest economic return (R\$ – \$10 returned per \$1 invested, a 7 : 1 to 10 : 1 benefit–cost ratio), vastly exceeding returns on tertiary education.

Crucial Distinction: ECCE is not a downward extension of formal primary schooling. It is not about forcing 3-year-olds to write the alphabet or sit silently at desks. It is an integrated web of care: **Healthcare + Nutritious Diet + Emotional Security + Playful Exploration**.

1.3 THE FIVE DEVELOPMENTAL DOMAINS (PANCHAKOSHA MODEL)

NCF-FS 2022 Core Framework

DOMAIN & KOSHA	CORE COMPETENCIES & DEVELOPMENTAL FOCUS	CLASSROOM / LEARNING CENTRE ACTIVITY
1. Physical–Motor (Annamaya Kosha)	Gross motor coordination (running, jumping, balancing) and fine motor dexterity (pincer grasp, hand–eye coordination, finger isolation).	Clay pinching, bead stringing, balancing on a taped line, free outdoor tag games, crawling through tunnels.
2. Socio–Emotional & Ethical (Pranamaya & Manomaya)	Self-identity, emotional self-regulation, empathy, sharing, turn-taking, following classroom routines, resolving peer friction.	Circle time emotion talks (“How do you feel today?”), dramatic role-play (doctor–patient, market), cooperative clean-up games.
3. Cognitive Domain (Vijnanamaya Kosha)	Sensory perception, spatial reasoning, cause-and-effect understanding, seriation, pattern identification, early number sense.	Sorting leaves by size, matching natural objects, nesting cups, simple wooden jigsaws, shadow-matching games.
4. Language & Early Literacy (Manomaya Kosha)	Emergent listening comprehension, oral articulation in mother tongue, phonological awareness, print awareness, scribbling.	Action songs, local nursery rhymes, interactive picture book reading (Big Books), puppet storytelling, sound-matching games.
5. Aesthetic & Cultural (Anandamaya Kosha)	Free creative expression, sensory enjoyment of colors, rhythm, body movement, appreciation of nature and cultural heritage.	Finger-painting, tearing and pasting paper collage, dance to folk beats, rangoli with flower petals and seeds.

1.4 FACTORS INFLUENCING HOLISTIC DEVELOPMENT

ECOLGY

- **Home Environment:** Secure parent–child attachment, verbal stimulation, nutritional adequacy, and absence of toxic domestic stress.
- **Community Ecosystem:** Safe sanitation, clean drinking water, open green play spaces, and community childcare support networks.
- **School / Centre Climate:** Child-friendly educators, absence of fear/punishment, culturally inclusive language, and hygienic infrastructure.

Bronfenbrenner's ecological model: Child is at the center of intersecting microsystems.

1.6 KEY INSTITUTIONAL AGENCIES IN ECCE

FRAMEWORK

- **ICDS (Anganwadi Services):** World's largest community-based outreach providing non-formal pre-schooling (3 – 6 years), supplementary nutrition, and immunization.
- **Samagra Shiksha (MoE):** Formalizing pre-primary classes (Ka–Shreni / Balvatika) co-located within government elementary schools.
- **Ministry of WCD:** Administering national ECCE policies, Poshan Abhiyaan, and early childhood care regulations.
- **Civil Society & Panchayats:** Local Mothers' Groups, Village Health Sanitation & Nutrition Committees (VHSNC), and community self-help groups.
- **Inter-ministerial convergence (MoE + MoWCD + MoHFW)** is mandatory under NEP 2020!

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UNIT 2: PEDAGOGICAL APPROACHES TO ECCE

Play-Based Learning Spectrum, Toy Pedagogy, Inquiry, and Crucial Curricular Concerns

WEIGHTAGE: 10 MARKS

2.1 THE PLAY-BASED LEARNING SPECTRUM

Play = Child's Serious Work

Play is the primary vehicle through which young children make sense of physical phenomena, master language, regulate impulse, and build social competence. In early childhood education, play is not an unstructured recess; it operates across a deliberate tripartite spectrum:

1. FREE PLAY (মুক্ত খেল)

Child-Directed

Initiated and governed entirely by the child. No adult-imposed rules, targets, or predefined outcomes.

- **Examples:** Constructing castles in the sandpit, scribbling freely on slates, dressing dolls in dramatic play.
- **Value:** Builds intrinsic autonomy, decision-making, emotional decompression, and raw creative imagination.

Role: Teacher observes unobtrusively to assess child preferences.

2. GUIDED PLAY (পরিচালিত খেল)

Gold Standard

Teacher prepares an intentional, resource-rich environment and gently scaffolds learning with open-ended prompts.

- **Examples:** Providing assorted river pebbles & asking: “Can you sort them from smoothest to roughest?”
- **Value:** Maximizes conceptual understanding while preserving child agency and playful excitement.

Role: Teacher is an active conversational partner and scaffold.

3. STRUCTURED PLAY (নিয়মবদ্ধ খেল)

Teacher-Led

Organized games designed by the educator with specific rules, sequential stages, and clear pedagogical targets.

- **Examples:** “Simon Says”, musical chairs, color-hunt races, rhythmic ring-a-ring-o-roses.
- **Value:** Teaches impulse control, turn-taking, auditory listening, and collective rule adherence.

Role: Teacher sets boundaries and models prosocial rules.

2.1.1 – 2.1.3 CORE PEDAGOGICAL MODES IN FOUNDATIONAL LEARNING

2.1.1 Toy-Based Learning

Using indigenous, low-cost local toys (clay figurines, wooden carts, nesting cups, spinning tops, cloth puppets). Toys serve as tangible thinking tools converting abstract mathematical and spatial concepts into concrete tactile manipulation.

2.1.2 Inquiry-Based Learning

Stimulating natural wonder through guided discovery. Instead of lecturing, the educator asks: “Why do leaves float while stones sink?” Children test hypotheses in water basins, observe shadows, and record leaf impressions.

2.1.3 Songs, Rhymes, Art & Craft

Action rhymes and traditional folk lullabies build phonemic sensitivity and auditory memory. Sensory art (finger painting, clay squishing, paper tearing) strengthens wrist bones and pincer dexterity necessary for later writing.

2.2 CRITICAL CURRICULAR ISSUES AND CONCERNS IN ECCE

Exam Anchor

1. Multilingualism (বহুভাষিকতা)

Young children think and process emotions in their **Home Language (L1)**. Forcing an unfamiliar school medium causes mutism and anxiety. The ECCE classroom must embrace code-switching and use home language as a scaffold.

2. Inclusion & Diversity

ECCE settings must accommodate children with special needs (CWSN), first-generation learners, and socially marginalized groups with zero discrimination. Universal Design for Learning (UDL) applies from age 3.

3. Gender Neutrality

Eliminate gender stereotypes early. Boys should participate freely in kitchen/doll dramatic corners, and girls must be actively encouraged in block building, climbing, and ball sports.

4. The Hazard of Premature Formal Instruction (“The 3R Trap”)

Forcing children under 6 into rote memorization, repetitive blackboard copying, tests, and heavy homework causes severe cognitive burnout and “school phobia”. Their neuromuscular skeletal systems are not ready for rigid pencil grips; early drilling damages intrinsic curiosity!

5. True School Readiness

School readiness is a **two-way street**: (1) Children ready for school, (2) Schools ready for children, and (3) Families ready to support. It is not passing an admission test, but achieving emotional and physical self-help maturity.

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UNIT 3: PLANNING AND MANAGEMENT OF ECCE CLASSROOM

Balanced Schedules, Activity Corners Architecture, Theme Webs & Family Engagement

WEIGHTAGE: 9 MARKS

3.1 CORE PRINCIPLES OF PLANNING A BALANCED DAILY SCHEDULE

An effective ECCE schedule maintains equilibrium across physical, mental, and social energies throughout the day. The routine must balance four fundamental pedagogical dichotomies:

Active ↔ Quiet

Balancing high-energy outdoor running with quiet book-reading.

Indoor ↔ Outdoor

Balancing tabletop fine-motor tasks with open sand and water exploration.

Child-Led ↔ Teacher-Guided

Balancing autonomous free exploration with structured group circles.

Individual ↔ Group

Balancing private solitary play with collaborative cooperative games.

3.2 CLASSROOM MANAGEMENT & THE 5 CORE ACTIVITY CORNERS

Physical Space As 3rd Teacher

In an ECCE classroom, rigid rows of benches are prohibited. The space is organized into well-demarcated **Activity Learning Corners (শিক্ষার কোণ)** where materials are accessible on low, open shelves at the child's eye level:

1. Dramatic Play / Doll Corner

Equipped with old clean clothes, kitchen utensils, cloth dolls, empty cartons. Children recreate home experiences, decompress anxieties, and develop emotional empathy.

2. Book / Reading Corner

Well-lit space with a clean mat and low display racks featuring Big Books, pictorial storybooks, touch-and-feel books. Fosters print awareness, left-to-right orientation, and love of literature.

3. Block Building & Meth Corner

Wooden blocks, nesting boxes, geometric plastic shapes, counters, seeds, measuring cups. Lays the concrete foundation for spatial relations, balance, and early number concepts.

4. Art & Creative Sensory Corner

Non-toxic clay/dough, child-safe safety scissors, glazes, chalks, colored paper scraps, and leaves for tearing, pasting, stamping, and tactile hand manipulation.

5. Discovery / Science Corner

Magnifying glasses, sea shells, different soil types, seeds for sprouting, magnets, and water basins to explore floating vs sinking phenomena.

Outdoor Play Area

Level ground, sandpit, balancing logs, discarded tires, child-safe swings, and water troughs. Develops vestibular balance and gross physical stamina.

3.3 DESIGN OF THEME-BASED INTEGRATED PLANNING

Instead of teaching isolated “subjects”, ECCE organizes learning around familiar life themes (e.g., Theme: “Water” / “Plants” / “Our Family”):

- **Language:** Singing rhymes on rain; water vocabulary.
- **Cognitive:** Floating vs sinking experiments in basins.
- **Physical:** Pouring water across different-sized containers.
- **Aesthetic:** Blue water painting; paper boat origami.
- **Socio-Emotional:** Talking about clean water habits & sharing.

3.4 PARENTAL AND COMMUNITY ENGAGEMENT

Parents are the child's first educators. ECCE centers must actively involve them:

- **Grandparents' Storytelling:** Inviting local elders to narrate indigenous folk tales and songs.
- **Mothers' Circles:** Workshops on positive discipline, local weaning diets, and child health tracking.
- **Community Toy Banks:** Mobilizing local carpenters and tailors to make low-cost wooden blocks and puppets.

A vibrant ECCE center reflects its community's culture and heritage!

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UNIT 4: ASSESSMENT IN ECCE & QUALITY STANDARDS

Continuous Observational Assessment, Holistic Progress Card (HPC) & 8 Key Standards

WEIGHTAGE: 8 MARKS

4.1 CORE PRINCIPLES OF ASSESSMENT IN EARLY YEARS

Zero Formal Exams

Assessment in early childhood is conducted **for learning** and **as learning**, never *of learning* in a summative, pass–fail sense. The core tenets are non-negotiable:

No Pen-and-Paper Tests

Formal sit–down tests, grades, marks, and rankings are strictly prohibited by NEP 2020 and NCF-FS.

No Negative Labelling

Children must never be assessed as “weak”, “dull”, or “slow”. Assessment highlights progress and growth trajectories.

Naturalistic Observation

The educator observes the child unobtrusively during spontaneous play, peer interaction, and daily routines.

Individual Comparison Only

A child is compared only to their own past performance, never against peers in the classroom.

4.2 & 4.3 THE HOLISTIC PROGRESS CARD (HPC) & OBSERVATIONAL TOOLS

360-Degree Evaluation

The **Holistic Progress Card (HPC)** is a 360-degree, multidimensional record that captures the unique capabilities of each child across all five developmental domains. It synthesizes four distinct evaluative voices:

1. Self-Assessment:

Child marks their own feelings using smiling/thoughtful smiley stamps on activities they enjoyed.

2. Peer Feedback:

Peers express who helped them during block building or shared lunch during circle time.

3. Teacher Observation:

Descriptive narratives of milestone attainment, persistence, and social warmth recorded in journals.

4. Parent Reflection:

Inputs from parents on child habits, self-care routines, sleep, and emotional patterns at home.

Portfolios:

A curated chronological folder of child drawings, clay pictures, scribbles, and collage work showcasing growth across the year.

Anecdotal Notes:

Brief factual narrative logs capturing significant behavioral events in context without teacher bias.

Checklists:

Developmentally sequenced milestone indicators marked periodically (e.g., “Can jump with both feet off the ground”).

4.4 EIGHT KEY STANDARDS FOR ENSURING QUALITY IN ECCE

1. Adult–Child Interaction:

Warm, responsive, sensitive; safe caregiving ratio (1 : 20 for pre-school, 1 : 10 for toddlers).

2. Play-Based Curriculum:

Contextualized, age-appropriate, grounded in concrete experiences and joyful games.

3. Physical Space & Safety:

Clean, well-ventilated, well-lit, barrier-free, hazard-free, child-accessible shelves.

4. Health, Nutrition & Hygiene:

Clean drinking water, child-friendly toilets, routine health check-ups, hot balanced meals.

5. Continuous Assessment:

Observational, non-punitive, documented through portfolios and the Holistic Progress Card.

6. Inclusivity & Equity:

Respect for all languages, cultures, genders, and welcoming children with special needs.

7. Community Involvement:

Active parental involvement, local artisan partnerships, regular mothers' meetings.

8. Qualified Educators:

Trained in early childhood pedagogy, exhibiting patience, warmth, and ethical commitment.

★ PAPER S1.2 PRACTICUM & INTERNAL ASSESSMENT BLUEPRINT (15 MARKS)

Syllabus 2026

ECCE Practicum Assignment & Portfolio

10 Marks

Internal Unit Test

5 Marks

Prescribed Practicum Tasks:

1. **Theme-Based Project Design:** Select any one universal theme (e.g., *Flowers, Birds, Vegetables, Water, Family, Community Helpers*) and prepare age-appropriate activities and concrete TLMs spanning all five developmental domains (Physical, Cognitive, Language, Socio-Emotional, Aesthetic).
2. **Daily Programme Scheduling:** Develop an optimal daily routine schedule for Ka–Shreni / Pre-Primary demonstrating an effective balance of active/quiet, indoor/outdoor, and child-led/teacher-guided learning.

SIP-I Internship Linkage (2 Weeks):

During School Internship I, trainees will observe Ka–Shreni transactions for 5 days, document activity corners, implement their prepared theme-based TLM, and prepare an analytical observation report countersigned by the school head.